

Chapter 82-6

Liang Shi said: "I'll only take up a little bit of your time."

Qi Jiao still shook her head: "What you mentioned before—I don't want to do it. Don't come looking for me anymore. There won't be any results."

After saying this, she turned to leave, but Liang Shi suddenly lowered her voice and said: "What about Gu Zhaoyuan then?"

Qi Jiao suddenly stopped in her tracks and turned to look at her. She opened her mouth to say something but pressed her lips together instead. Tears glistened in her eyes. She clenched her fists tightly, then released them.

She gritted her teeth to suppress her sadness, and when she looked at Liang Shi, her voice was cold and hard: "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

"What about Gu Yingbo then?" Liang Shi continued. "He's currently in a half-mad, half-foolish state. Does that also have nothing to do with you?"

"What?" Qi Jiao's eyes widened instantly. "Why would he go mad?"

Tears fell from Qi Jiao's eyes. "You're lying to me, aren't you? Are you trying to trick me?"

"No." Liang Shi called her by her original name in a low voice. "Gu Xingyue, I wish I were tricking you, but this is all true."

"You....." Qi Jiao was stunned. She pulled Liang Shi to the side of the road and looked up to ask her: "How exactly did you find out?"

"Part guessing, part logical deduction." Liang Shi said. "I just happened to discover it. Although I don't know what conditions Yang Jiani promised you, I know that Dean Gu going mad is related to you. You've endured all these years without going to see Dean Gu and Gu Zhaoyuan because you were afraid of implicating them, right? Yang Jiani must have used them to threaten you, right? So does Yang Jiani have some leverage over Dean Gu? To the point that you had to suffer so much. And we deduced that Dean Gu became this way out of guilt after witnessing you being abused by Yang Jiani."

Gu Xingyue clenched her fists tightly. "What... what do you mean by this?"

Her mouth was slightly open, her face full of disbelief.

Seeing her in this state, Liang Shi could only briefly tell her what she knew, then let her consider whether what she was doing now was worth it.

After thinking, Gu Xingyue still wanted to refuse, but when the words reached her lips, she couldn't say them.

She could only say in a trembling voice: "Let me think about it."

Liang Shi nodded: "I'll give you enough time. Don't worry—if anything happens with Dean Gu, I'll notify you immediately. Don't act any differently at the Qi family either, so you won't... get hurt again."

Hearing this, a trace of confusion flashed in Gu Xingyue's eyes. "Why are you being so good to me?"

Liang Shi smiled gently. "Because an older sister should protect her younger sister."

After saying this subconsciously, even Liang Shi was startled.

Why... did she say that?

It was as if someone had once said this to her.

After all, given the current situation, Gu Xingyue was actually older than her.

Gu Xingyue was also confused, so Liang Shi explained: "Qi Jiao-jiejie¹ once said this to me, so I want to seek justice for her death."

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Liang Shi took Rainbow to the gathering place, and the whole way there, she still couldn't figure out why she had said those words.

In the end, she could only attribute it to Qi Jiao having once said this to her.

The Qi Jiao she saw in her dreams was too warm—a sun that carried its own light source even while in darkness.

Liang Shi thought that she must have received a lot of protection from her when she was little, which was why she didn't want her to die without clarity now.

The person was clearly already dead, yet there was another person taking her place.

At the evening gathering, Liang Shi was the main character, so everyone kept pushing her to drink.

She didn't refuse anyone, and soon she had drunk a bit too much. She couldn't even hold on for a second round, and everyone laughed at her poor alcohol tolerance.

After drinking too much, Liang Shi didn't have those bad habits of being stubborn or trying to act tough. She just sat there gently, smiling serenely. "Yeah, I thought I could really hold my liquor."

This made everyone burst into laughter, all saying she was acting cute and begging for mercy.

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned and shook her head. "I'm not acting cute. At most, it counts as begging for mercy."

They partied until after nine, and it was almost time to disperse. Everyone had drunk quite a bit and pulled Liang Shi aside to speak from the heart.

For example, when she first arrived at the company, they really couldn't stand her, but after getting to know her, they felt that Xiao Liang² was really nice—sitting in the office, she was a beautiful sight.

Liang Shi said to everyone: "Then let's all keep in touch."

"Come on, you're going to be a big star in the future." Everyone said. "How are we supposed to keep in touch?"

"Even as a big star, I'm still Xiao Liang." Liang Shi said modestly.

Those who had cars basically all called for designated drivers³. Just as Li Ran was about to call a designated driver for Liang Shi, Liang Shi's phone rang.

Li Ran swiped to answer for Liang Shi and held it up to her ear.

The tipsy Liang Shi answered groggily: "Hello?"

Xu Qingzhu could tell from her voice. "Had too much to drink?"

"Who's this?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She announced herself coldly: "Xu Qingzhu."

Liang Shi's brain froze for a few seconds, then she broke into a deeply satisfied smile. Her voice lowered, carrying a faintly flirtatious undertone: "Oh, it's my wife~"

Footnotes:

¹ **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Chinese term for "older sister." Liang Shi is referring to Qi Jiao (the real one who died) as an older sister figure.

² **Xiao Liang (小梁)**: "Xiao" (小) meaning "little" or "young" is a common prefix added to surnames in Chinese as an affectionate or casual way to address someone, especially a younger colleague or friend. So "Xiao Liang" is an endearing way to call Liang Shi.

³ **Designated driver (代駕)**: In China, there are professional designated driver services where you can hire someone to drive your car home for you if you've been drinking. This is different from the Western concept of having a friend be the designated driver—it's a paid service where someone comes to wherever you are and drives your own car for you.